

two, Vallabhbhai himself went to England, where he brilliantly cleared his Bar examinations.

The steel that others saw in Patel was forged in the fires of sacrifice. His readiness to let go was displayed thrice in relation to Nehru. Responding each time to Mahatma Gandhi's steer, Patel stepped aside in 1929, 1937 and 1946 so that Nehru could become the Congress president. No hesitation marked any of the three gestures, but a strong stipulation accompanied all of them: Vallabhbhai's own independent role and views would have to be honoured. And they were.

This ability to lay his ego aside gave Patel a force that more than compensated for health problems. It also helped him gain a hold over the party and, after Independence, over the services, which matched Nehru's superior ability to communicate with the masses in Hindi and with the elite in English. The result was that for 15 years—from the start of 1936 to the end of 1950—Patel and Nehru served India as a leadership duo, despite several sharp differences. Until 1945 the two together, under Gandhi's guidance, led the Indian National Congress. From 1945 to 1948, when Gandhi was assassinated, the two led the Congress more or less independently of him, though at times turning to him as an umpire. From 1947 to 1950 Patel and Nehru formed the duumvirate of India.

As for Patel's realism, it is well known that his greatest post-Independence accomplishment—the integration of 500-plus princely states—was founded on a combination of strength and wisdom. The princes were willing to make way for democracy under the persuasion of a strong man who met their interests to



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Q1: Why is Godhra important in his life?

A: He set up his first household with his wife Jhaverba here

Q2: Which game did he enjoy playing?

A: Bridge

Q3: Which language did Mahatma Gandhi teach Patel?

A: Sanskrit

Q4: Which military operation is Patel famous for?

A: Operation Polo, the Indian military operation which resulted in the integration of the state of Hyderabad into the Union of India. He ordered it in 1948.

Q5: Who played Patel in Ketan Mehta's biopic *Sardar*?

A: Paresh Rawal

a reasonable extent, and who treated them with dignity.

Patel's realism also governed his decisions on what might be seen as the Left-Right and Hindu-Muslim issues that assailed India on Independence. Like every other human heart, Patel's heart had its preferences and dislikes. But his head saw with clarity that Gandhi's vision of an India which would give equal rights to all its citizens, including the vulnerable, was the sound one.

Five days after Gandhi's assassination, Patel wrote to Nehru: "We both have been lifelong comrades in a common cause. The paramount interests of our country and our mutual love and regard, transcending such differences of outlook and temperament as existed, have held us together. I had the good fortune to have a last talk with Bapu for over an hour before his death. His opinion also binds us both."

For India's sake Patel refused to lend his sacrifice-based strength to any narrow goal. His differences with Nehru included some over foreign policy. Though Nehru was the Congress's recognised foreign affairs expert, Patel's grasp was often clearer, as the Nehru-Patel exchange over China and Tibet revealed. Even when Nehru seemed unwilling to modify his stand on various issues, Patel refused to pit himself against him, holding his ground against impatient lieutenants eager for a confrontation.

At times in history, sacrifice and strength have been invoked in anger, for revenge, and in order to dominate. As wise as he was strong, Patel used his steel only for India's unity.

The author is a well-known scholar and political activist. He is the grandson of Mahatma Gandhi.